

Stuck in a loop: Sanju Samson's journey with India's T20 side over the past year has swung wildly between eye-catching flair and familiar frustration. R. RAGU

picked up on. From the start of 2024 to October 2025, pacers bowled 40% of their balls outside off to him; that figure has risen to 49% since. His SR against these balls is a measly 72.

Partnering him is Sanju Samson, who is back at the top of the order, but the series against England last year exposed his weaknesses against fast, bouncy deliveries in the 8–12 m range. In the IPL from 2022 to 2024, Samson faced fast balls that rose to a mean height of 0.96 m at the crease from this length, and averaged 26.75 at a strike rate of 147. Against England in 2025, he got out five times, facing 26 such balls, scoring just 32 runs. The average height of these deliveries at the crease was 1.12 m, a steep hike. At the World Cup, Samson could be troubled by fast bowlers with extra bounce likely to bowl inside the PowerPlay: Jofra Archer, Marco Jansen, Josh Hazlewood and the ilk. His sub-10 averages against the stronger international sides and his recent failures against New Zealand might push him out of the team, with the in-form Ishan Kishan taking his place.

Moving down the order, Tilak Varma is a high-intent batter against pace, but his flair against the faster bowlers hides his issues against spin. Most worryingly, he can be tied up by a slow left-arm bowler from around the wicket. Against incoming spin in the 2–6 m range, pitched on off stump or straighter, Tilak strikes at a 104 SR in the IPL and T20Is played in India. The average left-hand batter strikes at 124 for the same balls. With Suryakumar Yadav slotted in at number four and weak against slow left-armers, India might be pairing two batters who can be easily tied down by left-arm spin. Good T20 sides look to minimise such clusters of negative match-ups, and Axar Patel could be the man to shake things up as a spin-hitter at 4



or 5. Moreover, if Kishan replaces Samson at the top, India will have three left-handers starting, which is not ideal.

Ideally, Hardik Pandya would walk in at number five. His recent hitting profile has tilted towards spin-bashing, with noticeable weaknesses appearing against hard-length and short balls. However, he still does well against slot and yorker-length pace, and to

maximise the spin deliveries Axar can face, Hardik has to move down and be the “pivot” at number six. With his sound batting skills, he can also anchor the innings in case of a collapse, with others hitting around him.

While Rinku Singh is set to bat at seven, the number eight spot remains up for debate. India has looked to play Axar at that position recently, but that might be a waste

